Styrene (Asia)

By Luffy Wu, Yolanda Chen & Su Jie

UPDATED 14 OCT 2026 03:44

Market overview

AS OF 14 OCT 2026

Highlights

ICIS is reviewing the methodologies underpinning its styrene monomer (SM) FOB China and CFR China assessments. This is to ensure they remain fully aligned with the market's evolving trade patterns and continue to serve as accurate, representative pricing benchmarks for market participants. Your input on some of the key parameters shaping these two US dollar-denominated benchmarks is greatly valued. Please click here to participate in the survey.

- China's post-holiday SM market rallies on cost support and bullish capital sentiment
- Low inventories and domestic output keep China's SM fundamentals tight despite weak demand
- Volatility stalls China's export liquidity, pushing buyers and sellers to the sidelines

Styrene



Market commentary

China's post-holiday styrene monomer (SM) market rallied on 8 October, as strong upstream benzene costs, low inventories and speculative capital buoyed sentiment.

Sentiment cooled mildly on Friday, but the overall sharp gain had already reshaped export market dynamics and heightened regional SM users' cost concerns.

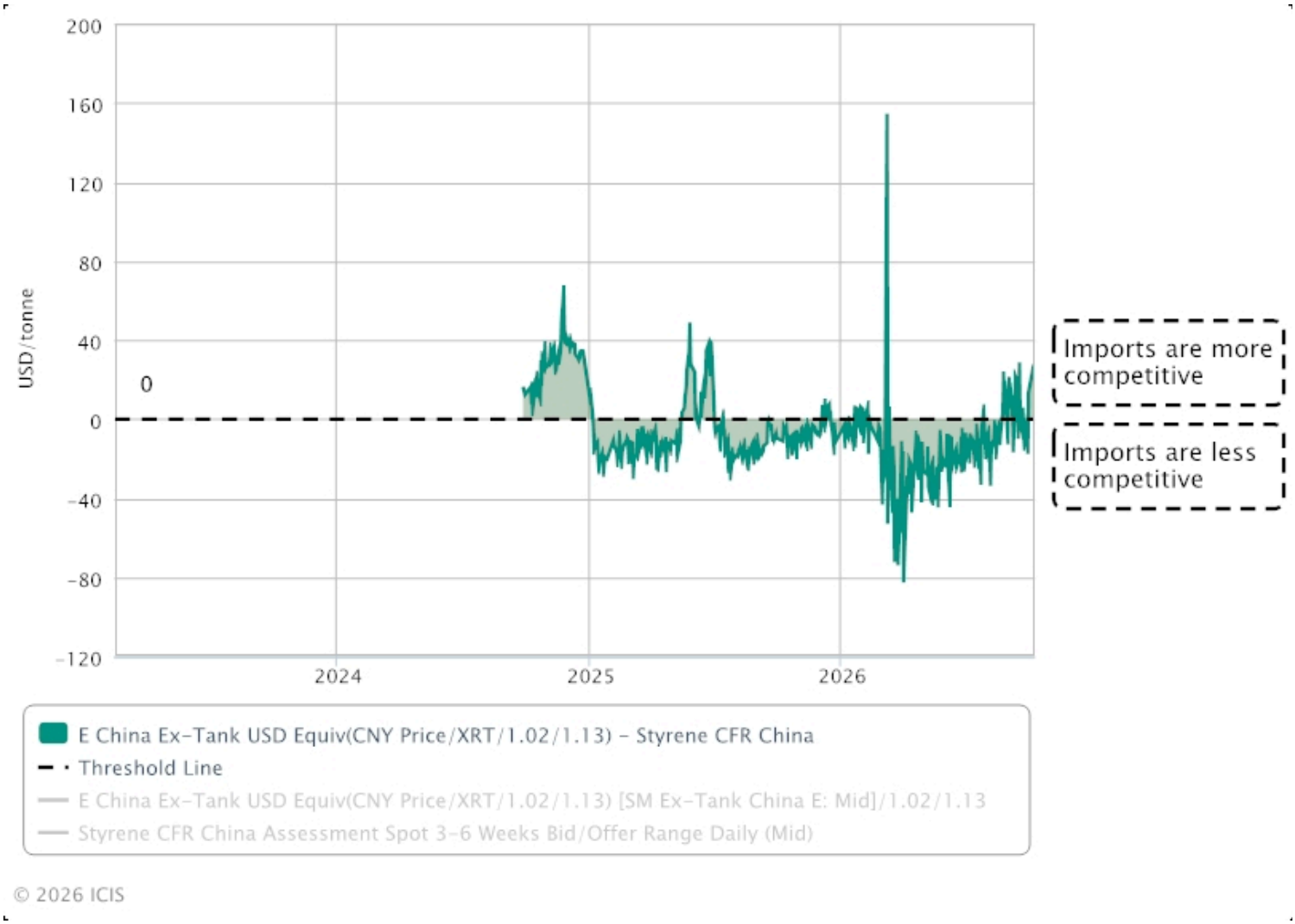
Supply tightness persisted even though both supply and demand are weak. High costs have limited SM producers' output, while the remaining demand is largely rigid and could be hardly cut further even as buyers face an unfavorable SM market. Persistently low inventories further added to near-term supply concerns.

High market volatility dampened China's SM export liquidity, as suppliers and buyers held diverging price views and lacked the confidence to make transactions at the prevailing levels.

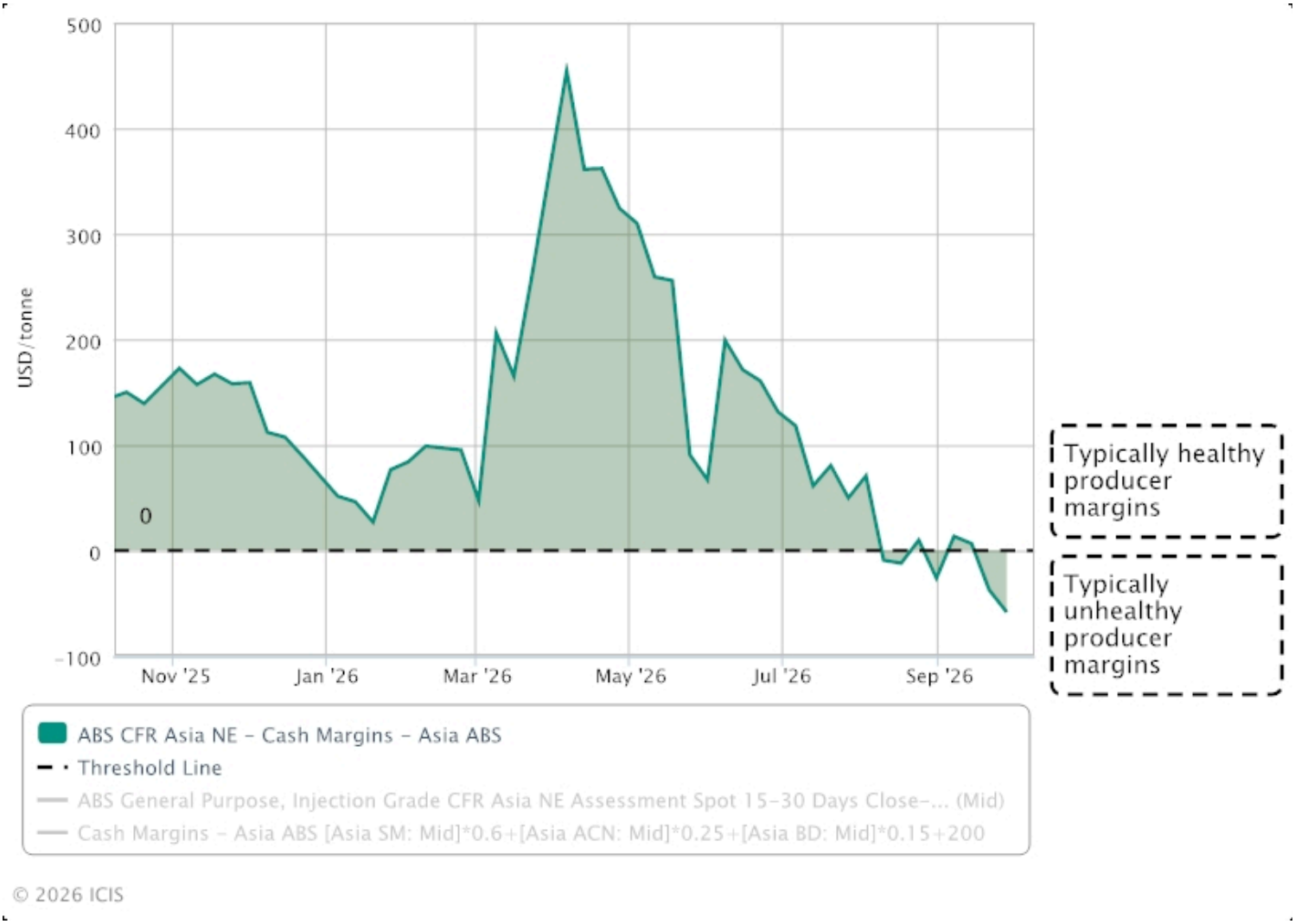
Elsewhere in Asia, spot quotes were slightly more flexible, with regional benzene volatility milder than in China.

Indian buyers worked to seek cargoes from alternative origins such as the rest of northeast Asia and southeast Asia, as China's export competitiveness was eroded by domestic volatility.

Import parity - China



Cash margins – ABS



© 2026 ICIS

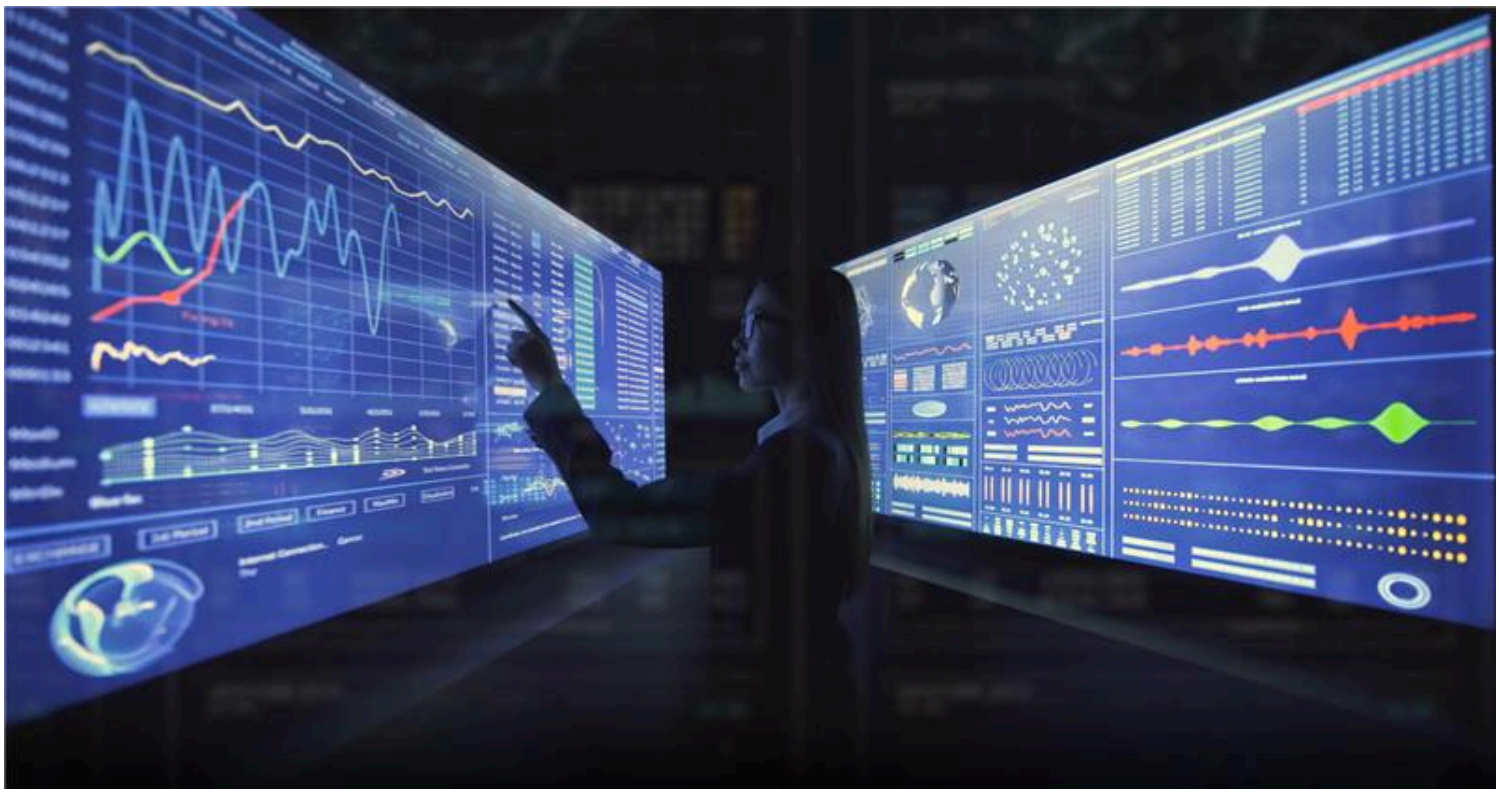
Outlook

- ICIS forecasts Asia's October market to remain supported by elevated feedstock costs and Middle East supply disruptions
- FOB China talks may stay limited until China's domestic volatility and backwardation ease
- Korean polymer run cuts and weak demand may cap spot Nov SM procurement

Forecast

AS OF 6 MAY 2025

Request access



Prices

AS OF 14 OCT 2026

Daily spot

Spot prices - daily

Name	Unit	Low change	Low price	High price	High change	Mid price	Mid change	Frequency	Published
Styrene CFR China Spot	USD/mt	0 (0%)	1,410	1,460	0 (0%)	1,435	0 (0%)	Daily	14 Oct 2026
Styrene FOB China Spot	USD/mt	0 (0%)	1,470	1,510	0 (0%)	1,490	0 (0%)	Daily	14 Oct 2026
Styrene Ex-Tank China E Spot	CNY/mt	+260 (+2.34%)	11,360 ▲	11,500 ▲	+100 (+0.88%)	11,430 ▲	+180 (+1.6%)	Daily	14 Oct 2026
Styrene Ex-Tank China E Forward	CNY/mt	+290 (+2.74%)	10,880 ▲	11,410 ▲	+120 (+1.06%)	11,145 ▲	+205 (+1.87%)	Daily	14 Oct 2026

Weekly spot

Spot prices - price range at close of assessment week

Name	Unit	Low change	Low price	High price	High change	Mid price	Mid change	Frequency	Published
Styrene FOB South Korea Spot Week Close	USD/mt	+55 (+3.86%)	1,480 ▲	1,550 ▲	+65 (+4.38%)	1,515 ▲	+60 (+4.12%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene CFR Asia NE Spot Week Close	USD/mt	+30 (+2.09%)	1,465 ▲	1,555 ▲	+60 (+4.01%)	1,510 ▲	+45 (+3.07%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene CFR Asia SE Spot Week Close	USD/mt	+35 (+2.42%)	1,480 ▲	1,580 ▲	+65 (+4.29%)	1,530 ▲	+50 (+3.38%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene Monomer CFR China Spot Week Close	USD/mt	+35 (+2.53%)	1,420 ▲	1,490 ▲	+55 (+3.83%)	1,455 ▲	+45 (+3.19%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026

Spot prices - price range for the week

Name	Unit	Low change	Low price	High price	High change	Mid price	Mid change	Frequency	Published
Styrene FOB South Korea Spot	USD/mt	+120 (+8.82%)	1,480 ▲	1,585 ▲	+100 (+6.73%)	1,532.5 ▲	+110 (+7.73%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene CFR Asia NE Spot	USD/mt	+95 (+6.93%)	1,465 ▲	1,590 ▲	+95 (+6.35%)	1,527.5 ▲	+95 (+6.63%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene CFR Asia SE Spot	USD/mt	+100 (+7.25%)	1,480 ▲	1,615 ▲	+100 (+6.6%)	1,547.5 ▲	+100 (+6.91%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene FOB China Spot	USD/mt	+120 (+8.7%)	1,500 ▲	1,570 ▲	+90 (+6.08%)	1,535 ▲	+105 (+7.34%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene Ex-Tank China E Spot	CNY/mt	+1000 (+9.71%)	11,300 ▲	12,000 ▲	+900 (+8.11%)	11,650 ▲	+950 (+8.88%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026
Styrene Monomer CFR China Spot	USD/mt	+100 (+7.58%)	1,420 ▲	1,525 ▲	+90 (+6.27%)	1,472.5 ▲	+95 (+6.9%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026

Name	Unit	Low change	Low price	High price	High change	Mid price	Mid change	Frequency	Published
Styrene Monomer Ex-Tank China E forward Spot	CNY/mt	+450 (+4.39%)	10,690 ▲	11,950 ▲	+950 (+8.64%)	11,320 ▲	+700 (+6.59%)	Weekly	09 Oct 2026

Monthly contract

Contract prices - import

Name	Period	Unit	Low change	Low price	High price	High change	Mid price	Mid change	Frequency	Published
Styrene CFR Asia NE Contract	Sep	USD/mt	+186.25 (+16.27%)	1,331.25 ▲	1,367.5 ▲	+183.12 (+15.46%)	1,349.375 ▲	+184.685 (+15.86%)	Monthly	25 Sep 2026

Monthly settlement price (MSP)

Name	Period	Unit	Price	Price change	Frequency	Published
Styrene Cargoes CFR China All Origins Spot	Sep	USD/mt	1,315 ▲	+172.5 (+15.1%)	Monthly	25 Sep 2026

Pricing commentary

Daily

China's styrene monomer (SM) market closed largely stable on Wednesday with high intra-day volatility.

Prices were strong in the morning amid cost support but tapered off in the afternoon, potentially due to strong buy-side resistance from polymer producers.

Sinopec raised benzene prices across its refineries by CNY200/tonne to CNY10,800/tonne, adding further pressure to SM production margins.

In the export market, enquiries were more active than in previous days, potentially due to the gradual sell-out of South Korea's November SM cargoes. Buyers have started to check concrete quotes from China and consider topping up the required volumes.

FOB China

Loading	FOB China spot prices ($/tonne)
Prompt (two weeks)	1,490-1,510
Forward (six weeks)	1,470-1,490

Exporters' quotes were notably higher in the morning, tracking gains in China's domestic market and export parity levels. They fell to similar levels as yesterday during the afternoon assessment window, following the retreat of the domestic market.

South China-origin H1 November loading cargoes were still offered at around $1,510/tonne, while cargoes from other origins were seen priced at mild discounts. Discussions were most likely to happen around $1,500/tonne, according to market sources.

No concrete talks were seen for the more forward H2 November cargoes. These forward cargoes were still valued at a moderate discount to the prompt H1 November cargoes, as backwardation in China's domestic market continues to lower suppliers' opportunity cost of loading more forward cargoes for export.

Floating offers for FOB China cargoes were also seen at around a $60/tonne notional premium on top of the November CFR China levels.

CFR China

Date	CFR China Spot Prices ($/tonne)
H1 Nov*	**1,440-1,460**
H2 Nov*	**1,410-1,430**
H1 Dec	1,380-1,400
H2 Dec	1,340-1,360

H1 Jan	1,320-1,340

**The assessment period is denoted in half months, reflecting cargo arrivals three to six weeks forward from the week of publication*

CFR China spot liquidity remained muted amid a lack of concrete spot interest from both the buy side and the sell side.

The H2 November is rolled over from previous day amid the lack of concrete fixed-price talks and largely similar import parity level in China at closure with yesterday.

The H1 November range was set at a $30/tonne notional spread to H2 November in line with feedback from market participants, considering the potential backwardation in China's domestic H1 November-H2 November market.

The steep intra-month and inter-month backwardation in China's SM market continues to reflect market players' views for a tighter supply-demand balance in the prompt market rather than the forward market.

The wide discount of the ICIS CFR China assessment to the FOB China benchmark reflects the structural disparity between the two benchmarks, including the more forward assessment period for CFR China and the 2% import duty included in the calculation for the import-parity level.

This poses a risk for market players pricing export cargoes against the CFR China benchmark as they are effectively using a forward price benchmark to value prompt-loading cargoes in China.

Weekly

FOB China

	Low end	High end
8-Oct	1,540	**1,570**
9-Oct	**1,500**	1,530

China's post-holiday SM export liquidity on Thursday and Friday was largely hampered by aggressive volatility in the domestic market, which made it difficult for suppliers to price spot export cargoes.

The volatility kept suppliers highly cautious about offering spot cargoes on a fixed-price basis, as dynamically hedging dollar-denominated sell positions in the volatile domestic futures market would be difficult.

Suppliers also largely avoided fixed-price spot discussions outside China's futures trading hours, given the risk involved.

Floating-price discussions were similarly challenging, as the spread between the ICIS FOB China and CFR China assessments widened on the significant backwardation in China's domestic market.

On the buy side, elevated FOB China quotes on both fixed and floating bases deterred some westbound buying interest.

Although China's domestic market eased on Friday, regional SM buyers preferred to wait for potentially cheaper quotes from alternative origins such as South Korea and southeast Asia next week, where suppliers could be slightly more flexible in offering and cargoes could benefit from India's import duty exemption, resulting in lower landed costs.

CFR China

	Low end	High end
8-Oct	1,440	**1,525**
9-Oct	**1,420**	1,490

Spot liquidity in China's import market remained entirely muted this week.

Although domestic prompt cargo availability is tight in China, as low SM plant operating rates under the high-cost environment have constrained supply, Chinese SM users showed no appetite for imports at this stage.

Slow end-consumption weighed on buying interest, while import cargoes arriving in forward terms would do little to ease the prompt supply tightness.

On the supply side, most regional suppliers are targeting spot sales to India, where export netbacks are notably better than from selling into China, where most demand is speculative buying.

Starting this week, discussions and price indications for H2 November arrival cargoes were considered for the daily CFR China assessment, which dragged down the low end of the CFR China range given the very steep backwardation between China's domestic H2 October and H2 November markets.

The steeply backwardated term structure reflects a prompt market that is expected to be far tighter than the forward market. While the prompt end of the curve is largely inflated by ongoing low inventories, low plant operating rates under high costs and active short covering in the SM derivatives market, the forward months factor in a potential easing of supply amid sluggish end-demand.

CFR NE Asia

South Korean SM users have started procuring November-arrival cargoes, but at a slow pace, as high offers circulating across the region have deterred buyers from committing to current spot levels.

Some Japan-origin cargoes were heard traded in limited volume at levels considered competitive against prevailing offers from other Northeast Asian origins. With only very limited Japan export volumes available, Korean buyers may still need to top up the remainder of November requirements from the rest of northeast Asia, where suppliers are mainly targeting India for higher export netbacks.

China's significant domestic market volatility and steep backwardation have made it harder for market players to value CFR South Korea cargoes on a CFR China floating basis.

Against regional supply tightness and stable import demand from India, Korean buyers are more likely to be price takers in November discussions.

Their spot requirements are nonetheless likely to stay modest, given slow downstream consumption of styrenics polymers and piling inventories. Some major Korean polymer producers are planning potential shutdowns or operating rate cuts over the rest of Q4, starting from late October.

The assessed floating premium is set wider at $45-65/tonne, with the low end including the Japan-Korea deal heard done and the high end reflecting more likely discussions levels for cargoes from the rest of NE Asia.

Type	Price ($/tonne)	Volume (tonnes)	Arrival	Origin
Deals	CFR China + mid 40s	2,000-3,000	November	Japan

CFR SE Asia

Spot procurement in the southeast Asian SM import market stayed minimal, as buyers found it extremely difficult to pass rising costs on to downstream users.

Amid slow end-consumption, most regional SM users kept spot purchases to a minimum and relied on contractual volumes, avoiding spot cargoes exposed to high costs and price risks.

On the supply side, SE Asian suppliers are focusing on potential export opportunities to India, where netbacks are better than from distributing cargoes within the region.

Buyers forced to cover short positions in the spot market would likely be price takers, given the lack of more economic options across Asia and stable Indian import demand that continues to support suppliers' selling indications.

The high end of the CFR SE Asia floating premium on top of CFR China was therefore mildly raised to $90/tonne, to a level suppliers consider more feasible for selling spot cargoes into the region.

FOB South Korea

South Korea's SM export discussions remained limited this week due to holidays in Korea. Market players mostly expect FOB South Korea talks for November-loading cargoes to kick off next week after the holidays.

Suppliers could anticipate a floating premium over CFR China similar to, or moderately higher than, that seen in the latest discussions and deals for October-loading cargoes, at around $60-70/tonne and above, according to market sources.

Although freight from South Korea may not be as competitive as from South China to India, sellers' slightly more flexible floating premiums and the duty savings under the India-Korea Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) are likely to keep November-loading FOB South Korea cargoes a prioritised option for westbound trades.

The floating premium on top of CFR China is set at $60/tonne, reflecting a likely discussion level for November FOB South Korea talks.

South Asia

India's local spot levels were higher in the late week, tracking the gains in China's domestic market, as China has been a major supplier of SM cargoes to India since March.

With China's domestic market turning more volatile, its export business was largely paused as both buyers and sellers adopted a risk-avoidance stance. The lack of fresh import offers in India also added moderate forward supply concerns, supporting late-week domestic spot levels.

Domestic downstream demand remained relatively stable, keeping Indian importers likely to stay active in the northeast and southeast Asian markets, seeking November-loading and November to early December-arrival cargoes next week.

With China's offers trending higher, buyers are likely to source from alternative origins such as South Korea and southeast Asia, where cargoes carry duty savings, and to top up the remaining volumes from China, where spot cargo availability is still sufficient to cover export business.

Type	Price (Rs/kg)
Price indications	Around 160

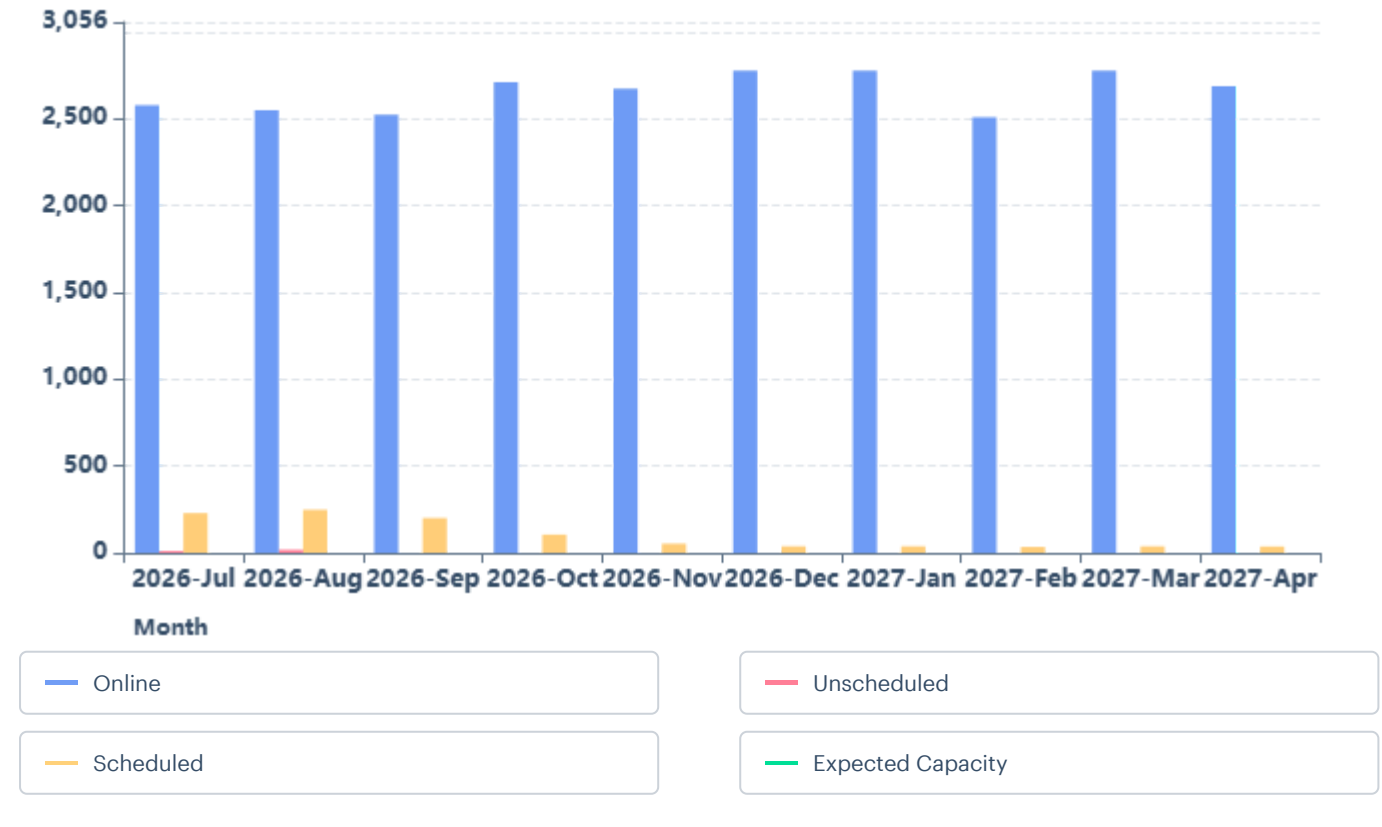
Supply and demand

AS OF 14 OCT 2026

Highlights

- China's SM supply and demand both weak, but rigid demand keeps SM availability tight
- Low operations amid high-cost environment to keep China's inventory rebound slow
- Stable Indian demand to pull regional supply toward export, tightening local availability

Capacity and shutdowns



Unit: '000 tonnes

Shutdowns

Location	Company	Site	Start	End	Plant No.	Cause	Capacity loss	Total annual capacity (kt)	Last updated
Taiwan	Formosa Chemicals and Fibre Corp.	Mai Liao	06 Jun 2025 (Market information)	01 Oct 2026 (Market information)	1	Scheduled	100% (est. 330.8 kt)	250	08 Jan 2026
Japan	Idemitsu Kosan	Tokuyama	29 Aug 2026 (Market information)	29 Oct 2026 (Market information)	1	Scheduled	100% (est. 20.4 kt)	120	18 Sep 2026
Japan	Idemitsu Kosan	Tokuyama	29 Aug 2026 (Market information)	29 Oct 2026 (Market information)	2	Scheduled	100% (est. 37.4 kt)	220	18 Sep 2026
Taiwan	Grand Pacific Petrochemical Corp.	Ta-sheh City	29 Aug 2026 (Market information)	16 Oct 2026 (Market information)	2	Scheduled	100% (est. 17.5 kt)	130	04 Sep 2026
China	Sinopec Anqing PC Co	Anqing	02 Sep 2026 (Market information)	15 Nov 2026 (Market information)	2	Scheduled	100% (est. 82.2 kt)	400	07 Sep 2026
Taiwan	Formosa Chemicals and Fibre Corp.	Mai Liao	07 Sep 2026 (Market information)	16 Jun 2027 (Market information)	2	Scheduled	30% (est. 81.4 kt)	350	11 Sep 2026
Taiwan	Taiwan Styrene Monomer	LIN Yuan	01 Oct 2026 (Market information)	31 Oct 2027 (Market information)	1	Scheduled	100% (est. 195.3 kt)	180	01 Oct 2026
Taiwan	Taiwan Styrene Monomer	LIN Yuan	01 Oct 2026 (Market information)	31 Oct 2027 (Market information)	2	Scheduled	100% (est. 173.6 kt)	160	01 Oct 2026

Capacity changes

Location	Company	Site	Plant No.	Type	Estimated start	New annual capacity (kt)	Capacity change (kt)	% Change	Last updated
China	Huajin Aramco Petrochemical	Panjin	1	New Plant	Jun 2027	700 ▲	700	100.00%	14 Oct 2026
China	Bright Lyondellbasell Petrochemical	Panjin	1	Expansion	Aug 2027	420 ▲	70	20.00%	22 Jul 2026

Value chain commentary

- In Singapore, major producer Aster Chemicals and Energy has declared force majeure; SM line 2 restarted at low rate in late September 2026 after the long pause since mid-March
- In Taiwan, major SM producer Formosa Chemicals & Fibre Corporation (FCFC) is operating line 3 at full capacity; SM line 1 remains paused FCFC restarted its SM line 2 to around 70% in H1 September
- In Taiwan, major SM maker Taiwan Styrene Monomer Corporation (TSMC) halted SM production starting from 1 October; both SM line 1 and line 2 have been shut
- In Taiwan, major SM maker GPPC has shut SM line 2 for scheduled maintenance until mid-October
- In South Korea, major SM maker Yeochun NCC (YNCC) has declared force majeure, cut operating rates to about 70%

- In South Korea, major SM maker LOTTE Chemical keeps operating rates at full capacity
- In Japan, major producer Idemitsu shut SM line 1, line 2 in Tokuyama for scheduled maintenance, while adjusting Chiba SM line run rate to full capacity
- In Saudi Arabia, major SM makers Petrokemya, CP Chem declare force majeure for SM

NE Asia average run rate*	S Korea	Japan	Taiwan
Previous week	73%	70%	65%
This week	73%	70%	60%

**S Korea SM plants in permanent structural shutdowns or extended periods of inactivity removed from run rate calculation starting from Jan 2026*

Average SM operating rate in China

Average operating rate at SM plants in China remains low at around 62.5%.

Previous week	63%
This week	62.5%

East China SM inventory (tonnes)

Total	Inventory	Arrivals	Consumption
30-Sept-26	31,400	20,150	28,350

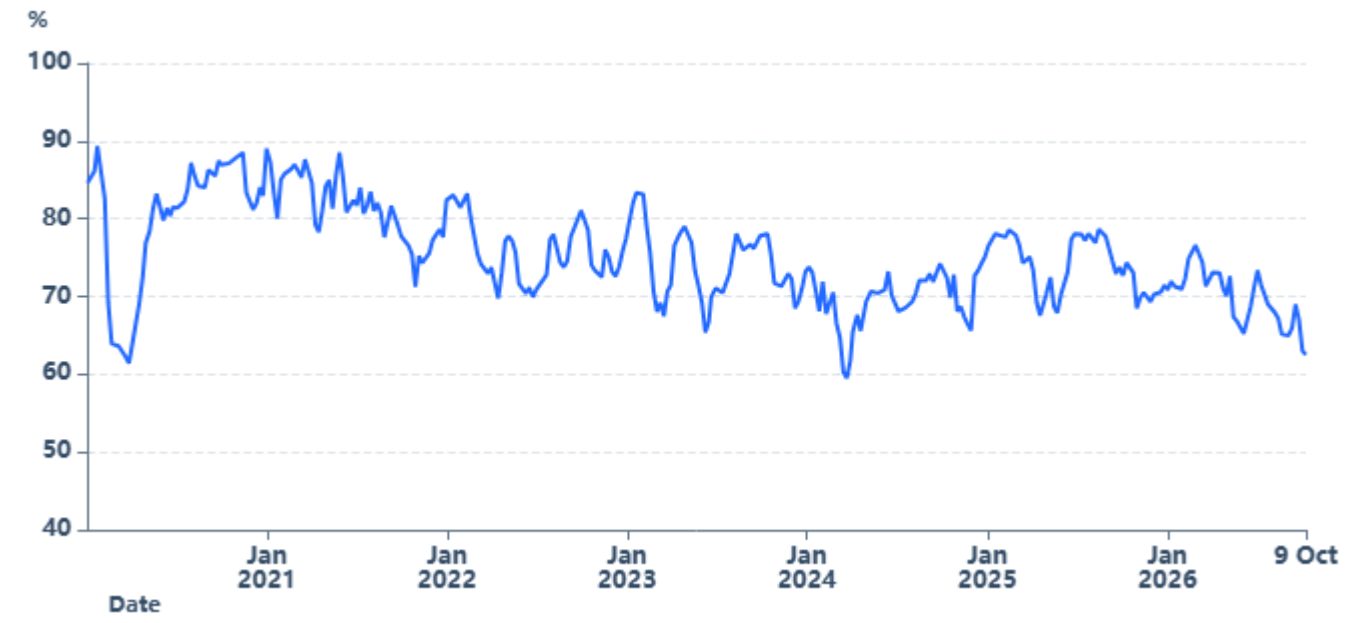
Upstream

Click here for the Asia feedstocks and petrochemicals weekly summary.

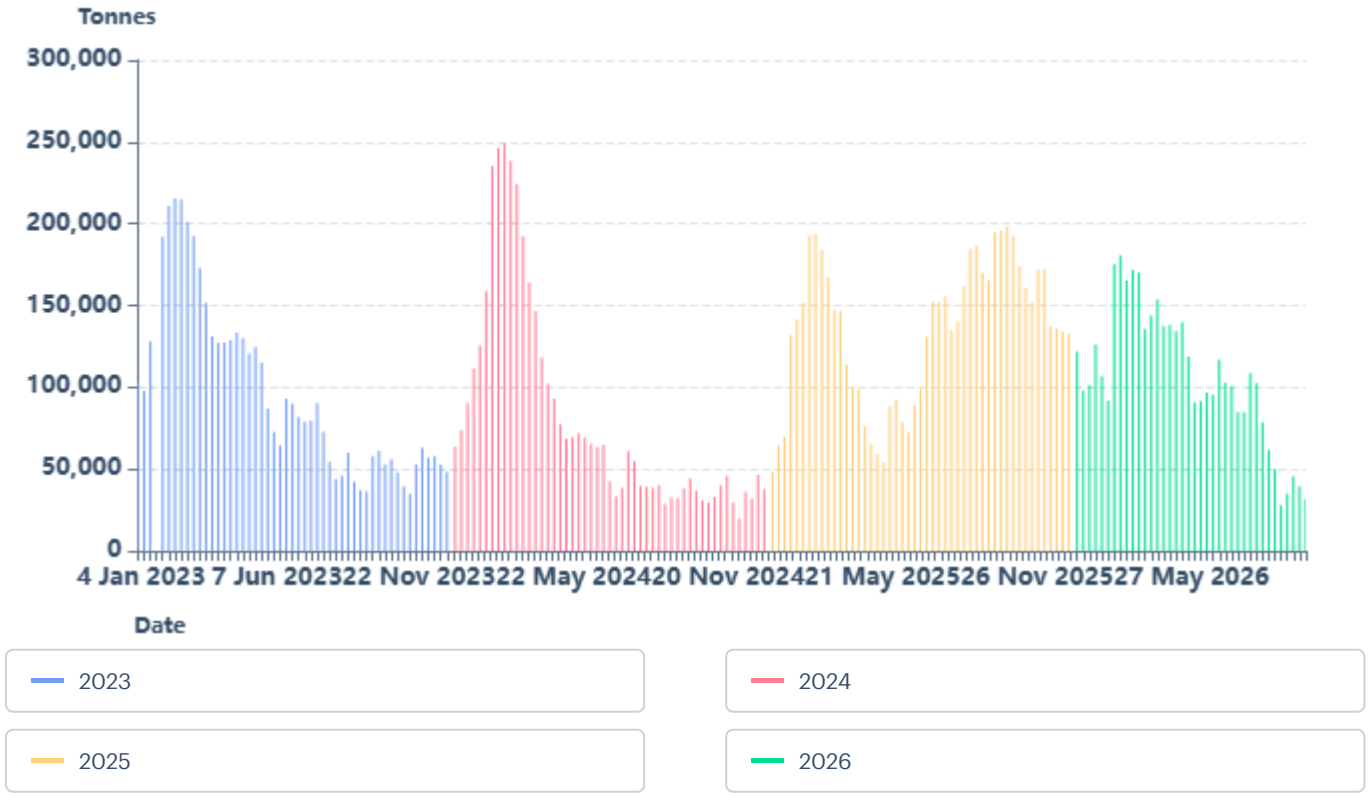
Downstream

Styrenics week-on-week import price comparison	Direction
Acrylonitrile butadiene styrene (ABS)	Firm
Polystyrene (PS)	Firm
Expandable polystyrene (EPS)	Firm

China SM operating rate



East China SM shoretank inventories



Feedstock spot prices

Name	Unit	Low price	Low change	High price	High change	Frequency	Date
Ethylene CFR NE Asia weekly	USD/tonne	1070	-30	1160	0	weekly	09 Oct 2026

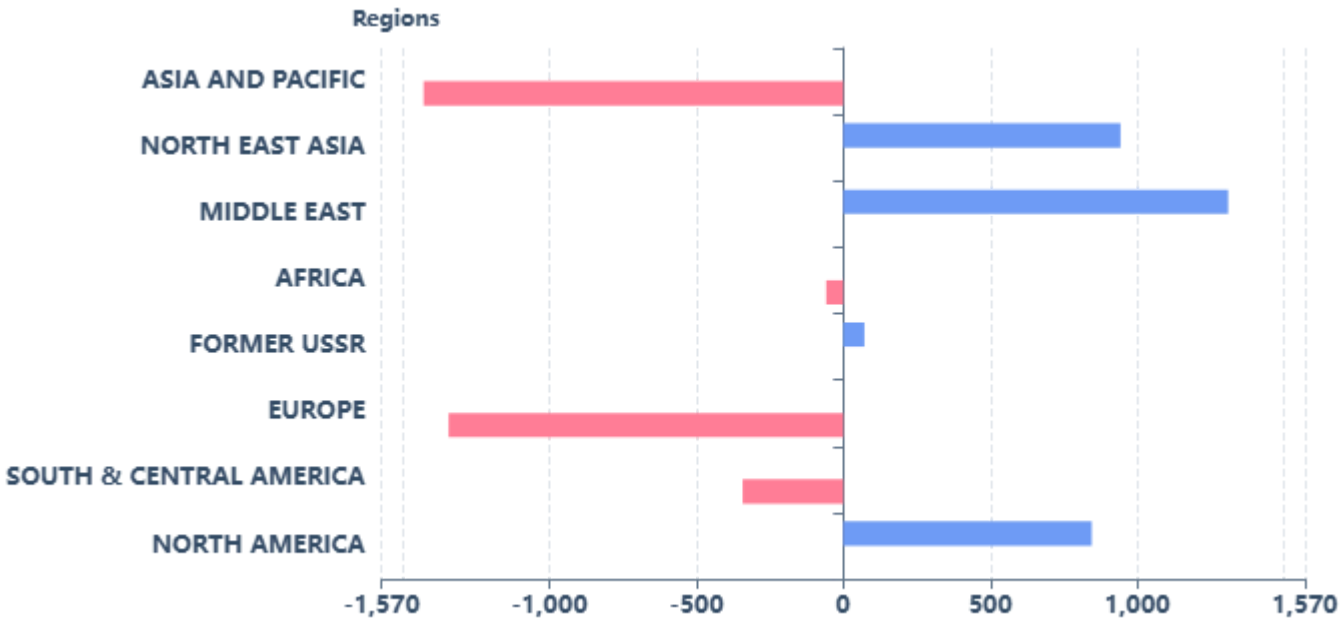
Feedstock spot prices

Name	Unit	Low price	Low change	High price	High change	Frequency	Date
Benzene NE Asia CFR close	USD/tonne	1325	50	1345	50	weekly	09 Oct 2026

Trade balance

AS OF 4 SEP 2026

2026 Trade Balance Forecast

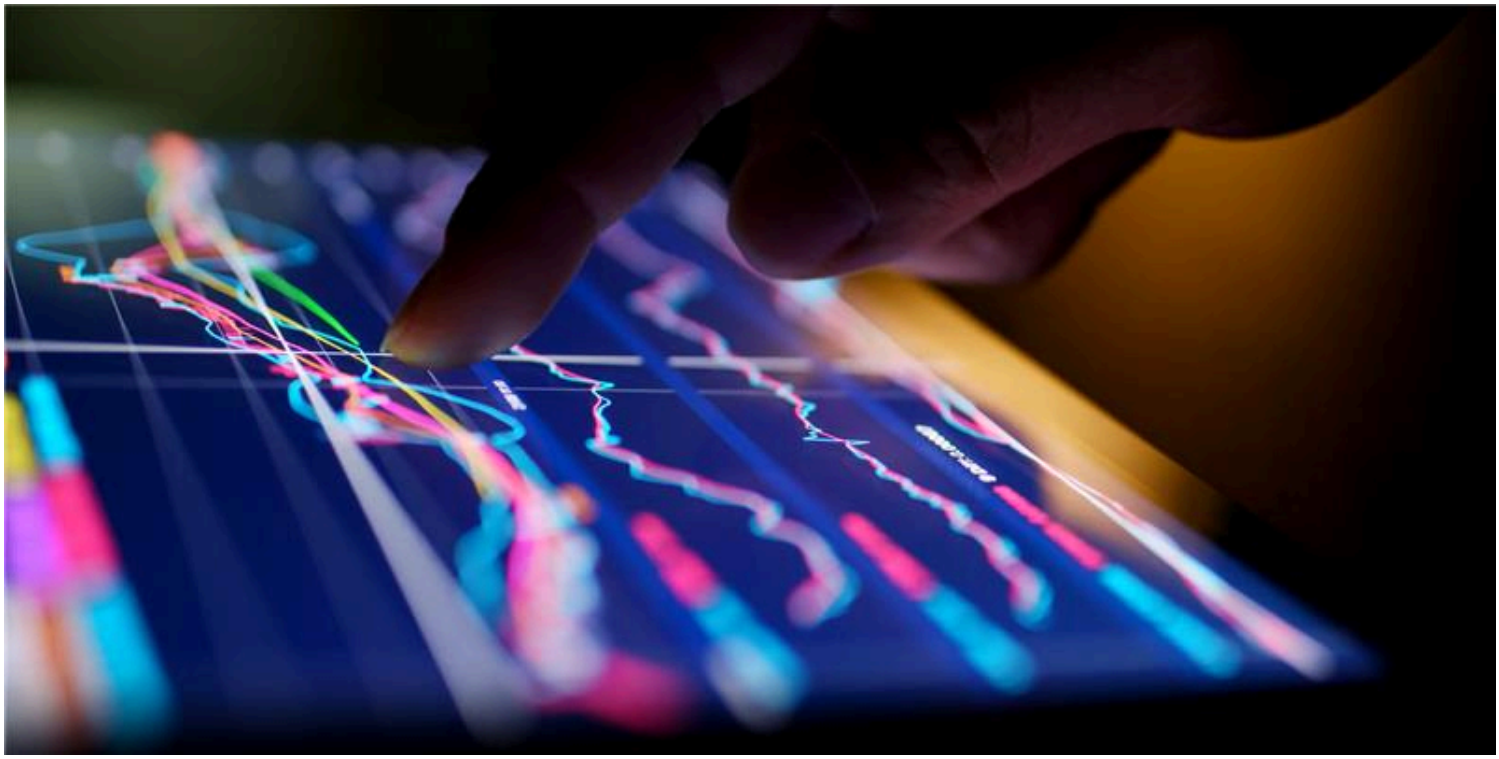


Net Exports (thousand tonnes)

Net Imports (thousand tonnes)

Margins

AS OF 6 MAY 2025



Styrene (Asia) | 14-Oct-2026 UTC. ICIS accepts no liability for commercial decisions based on the content of this report. Unauthorised reproduction, onward transmission or copying of the Styrene (Asia) Report in either its electronic or hard copy format is illegal. Should you require a licence or an additional copy of the Styrene (Asia) Report, please contact ICIS at sales.uk@icis.com

ICIS, LNRS Data Services Limited, 1-3 Strand, London, WC2N 5JR, United Kingdom. ICIS accept no liability for commercial decisions based on the content of this report. Copyright violation is a serious offence. Any distribution or forwarding of information that is not expressly permitted by your subscription agreement is a copyright violation. ICIS uses software to monitor unauthorised electronic redistribution of reports.

© 2026 LNRS Data Services Limited. ICIS is a member of RELX Group. www.icis.com

RELX